

CHAPTER 1

THE INFINITE ARCADE

This book is three years late.

I made a promise to readers who trusted me with their money and their hope, and then I couldn't deliver. The reason, when I finally let myself look at it clearly, was both embarrassing and fitting: I was writing a book about allyship, and it was making me a worse ally. Not to the people I was trying to serve — to myself, to the people closest to me, to the work itself.

I knew that helping people from a place of scarcity doesn't work. I'd built a whole framework around that idea. So I told myself I wasn't doing that. I was being responsible. I was staying in integrity. Which was all true, and also meant the guilt had nowhere to go. It went underground. The work went with it.

It wasn't until I gave myself permission to actually be mad — at myself, about the delay, about the gap between who I said I was and what I was doing — that I saw what was happening. I was holding myself hostage. Because I couldn't be perfect in the way I'd decided I had to be, I ended up doing the exact opposite of what I set out to do: making the work smaller, slower, less alive. Less fun.

Realizing this is what finally unlocked my ability to finish. I could see the pattern clearly, and I kept playing. It didn't have to disappear first. In fact, letting the charge of that awareness exist was what let me alchemize it into the book in your hands right now.

You're the person I made that promise to. And this is me showing up — late, imperfect, and in the game.

You are a Game Master. You have been running your own allyship campaign for years — whether you named it or not. You decided which harm in a moment got named out loud and which one slid past. You set the stakes with a single sentence, or by saying nothing at all. You did almost none of it on purpose. The one calling those moves has not been the conscious you; it has been the part that runs on default — inherited reflexes, old wounds, the face you reach for without checking whether it fits. Your unconscious has been the game master. It has run your allyship the whole time, and it plays by one rule: keep you safe. Helping the people you meant to serve was never its assignment. What changes now is that you take the seat — which is what this whole book is, and why so much of it is shadow work. Your shadow is the game master. You cannot take the controls from a player you refuse to look at.

You do not need to be perfect to begin. You only need to be willing to play.

You have done this before. You walk into a meeting or a dinner or a group chat and you catch something no one else in the room seems to catch, which is that a game is already running under the surface. Somebody gets talked over, or a decision lands on the person with the least power to absorb it, and the temperature drops while everyone keeps talking. You are the one who moves, changing who you look at and slowing the conversation down and saying the sentence that costs you something, even though nobody handed you that job. That pull, to step into a game no one invited you to play because you can see it and cannot leave it alone, is the call. You have been answering it since before you had a word for it.

Underneath it runs a feeling you have never fully worked through. It is closest to worry, the low and steady kind that never switches all the way off. You can see how the systems you were born into are built to wear people down, and you can see how little your moves seem to move the machine, and you keep playing anyway while the worry keeps running underneath the play.

Most calls to allyship arrive like a summons to court: formal, accusatory, and already halfway to sentencing. You are either with us or against us. You are either listening, learning, amplifying, or you are complicit. The game, they say, has already started. You're just late to the rules.

That was the beginner's game. You graduated from it years ago.

You are not here because you haven't tried. You've been doing the evolved version — the relational, emotionally literate, I've-done-my-work version — long enough to know that more trying isn't the answer. You've had the conversations. You've done the reading. You've carried the weight. And somewhere underneath all of it, you've been trying to pay down a debt you inherited — to restore something, to be the one whose effort finally offsets the damage. Most of the stories you tell about your allyship are how you're falling short. You are not burned out

from too little effort. You are burned out from trying to retire a debt that was never meant to be paid off — and some part of you has started to wonder whether the game itself is the problem.

Christina Maslach's research on burnout names its three dimensions: exhaustion, the depersonalization that distances you from the people you're serving, and the loss of any sense that your effort matters. Paul Gorski's work on activist burnout adds the mechanism that makes ours specific: when your activism is fused with your identity, you have no way to regulate the cost. When the work is who you are, there is no mechanism for saying "I've spent enough today." The selflessness the movement culture rewards is the same mechanism that empties you out.

The debt frame is the identity fusion made conscious: it's the story that justifies why you can't stop. You owe something you inherited rather than chose. And unlike a financial debt, there is no final payment — no moment when someone hands you a receipt. The debt was always designed to be unpayable. Recognizing that is accurate accounting.

The game frame is the medicine for this, and it works because a game does something specific to your relationship with the stakes. It puts distance between you and the outcome. That distance is detachment, the healthy kind: it lets you stay in a charged fight without the charge running you. You are playing this game. You are not the game. The player who is fused with the outcome can't play well. The player who is fused with the cause can't serve it for long.

Using the game frame also clears away most of the uncertainty that plagues people who want to be allies. A game gives you a set of rules. Once you've learned them, you no longer have to think about how to play, even while you're still figuring out how to win and succeed.

The people you've been most loyal to in this work already knew the vocabulary. You built it together. You assembled the frameworks in the college friend group, piece by piece, over years of conversations that felt like the most important conversations you'd ever had. You carried them into the progressive org spaces, where the right term signals that you're safe before you've done anything to prove it. You still use them in the dating profile and the group chat, where fluency in the language is the price of admission, and everyone pays it because the alternative is to start from scratch every time.

I have spent my whole adult life in those spaces, and I have needed them. The shared language does something good: it gives me permission to lower my guard and show up as myself. The same fluency that lets me in keeps other people out. It can also pass for the work itself. Speaking the language starts to feel like helping the people I am trying to serve, when all it has done is get me through the door. That is a game of its own, and it is one I have played for myself. The move looks like allyship. The payout lands in my safety and my belonging, and the person I meant to serve never sees a point of it.

Real allyship happens in plenty of places that game never reaches, and there, fluency earns you nothing. There are children who can receive care or not based on whether you

actually understand something, and your theory of harm is invisible to them. There are people from cultural traditions different enough from yours that the language of allyship arrives as an import, one more Western frame explaining their experience back to them. There are community organizations doing unglamorous, necessary work in a register with no political language at all, where nobody has ever said “center the marginalized” out loud and people are being fed.

You have watched this happen up close. In the summer of 2020, people who had never organized anything showed up ready to help, and some of the spaces they walked into asked them to master a vocabulary and a set of positions before they could hand out a meal or knock on a door. The impulse was earned. Newcomers with good intentions do real damage, and the language was a way to screen for care. Over time, though, the screening became the event. Getting the words right started to count as the help itself, and people who were ready to do the work heard that they had to speak correctly first. A good number of them left.

This is an old pattern wearing new clothes. Missionaries once required the people they came to serve to convert before they would hand out the food, and most of us recognize that now as a betrayal of the help itself. Fewer of us are willing to ask whether the vocabulary we have built does the same quieter thing: a set of conditions that has to be met before the real help arrives. Sometimes the vocabulary is necessary. The problem is that we almost never stop to assess whether it is.

The game you moved into has the same design flaw, and I want to be careful here because I ran it for years. The suffering that actually moves you is enormous and far away, and you cannot reach it. Helplessness like that does not resolve on its own. Left unmetabolized, it turns into a drive to control what you can, and what you can control is the people close enough to touch. The friend who votes wrong, the parent whose politics make you wince, the coworker who says the outdated thing in the meeting: each one becomes a mascot for the helplessness you never worked through. You set out to raise their consciousness the way Pygmalion set out to carve himself the perfect woman, and converting them starts to feel like doing something about the suffering you cannot reach. And the words make a very convincing receipt. You said the right thing, so surely you are helping.

The ones who refuse to be carved become the enemy. If they are not with you, they are the problem you are fighting, and that fight quietly eats the hours and the care you could have spent on someone who actually needed you. You pour everything into converting the people around you to your vision of the good, and I mean everything. Then one of them pushes back, and you hit the wall you cannot step around: you might have hurt someone by trying to help them, and you might never have asked whether they wanted your help in the first place.

That shock exposes the conflict the whole game is built on, and it is not a flattering one. Everything that makes you feel like a good person depends on other people needing your help. The role of the good ally only pays out while someone is still broken enough to need

saving, which means a quiet, well-hidden part of you has a stake in the problem never fully resolving. I know how that reads. It was true about me, and I had the framework that was supposed to prevent it. Your service runs on their need. The payouts are real and specific: the friends who love you for your fluency, your standing at work as the conscientious one, the small private certainty that you are one of the good ones. The game hands you every bit of it, and it stops paying the day you admit the game does not work. Walk away and you lose the things that told you who you were. Stay and you keep doing work you already know does not help.

Before you read on, one instruction. (Yes, already. You just walked in and I'm handing you homework. Stay with me.)

You came here to get better at this, and "this" will not hold still. Every year there is a new community to understand, a new history to catch up on, a new set of words to get right, and I promise you one more will emerge before you reach the last chapter. So you have been trying to study all of it at once, to be fluent in everyone, to never once be the person who says the wrong thing. I know this move intimately. I wrote a whole book about not doing this move, and I did it the entire time I was writing.

Here is the good news, and it happens to be the whole design of the book: you do not have to learn everyone. You learn one process, and you run it on one person, or one community, or one cause, all the way to the end. Then you shuffle up and run it again on the next one. That replay is on purpose. It is the difference between a book you finish and a game you keep coming back to. And you did not burn out from caring too much. You burned out from starting the process on everyone and finishing it with no one.

So pick one: the community you keep trying to help from the cheap seats, the cause that has quietly been billing you for years, or the person whose fight you want to stand next to without turning it into a documentary about your growth. Choose the one where you care the most and change the least (you already know which one it is), and bring it with you into every chapter. You do not have to fix it today. You just have to keep it where you can see it. This is where you pick up the controls.

THE MYTHS THAT KEEP YOU PLAYING THE WRONG GAME

Most people do not come to allyship empty-handed. They come carrying a few questions they would never say out loud. Am I good enough? Do I matter? Do I belong here? If I get this wrong, do I get cast out?

You answered those questions with myths, the way everyone does. Myths are how human beings make sense of a world too big to hold; they give reality a shape you can move around in. Here is what the guilt never tells you: every one of these myths is a solvable puzzle, and

this book hands you the moves to take each one apart. Just seeing the whole map of them, before you solve a single one, makes you a sharper ally than you were a page ago.

Allyship looks like the honorable place to bring those questions, which is exactly the trap. Bring them here and the question quietly flips: instead of asking whether you are good, you start trying to prove it, one act of help at a time. That is the master myth, allyship means being good, and it comes in ten versions. A few of them are almost certainly running you right now.

- Allyship means being good.
- Allyship means helping the less powerful.
- Allyship means fixing the problem.
- Allyship means sacrificing yourself.
- Allyship means paying down what you owe.
- Allyship means being seen doing it.
- Allyship means saying the right words.
- Allyship means following the right people.
- Allyship means never causing harm.
- Allyship means having the right framework.

(The app runs a short, unflattering diagnostic that tells you which of these are yours and hands each one back with the page that takes it apart. It scores how you actually behave, and it will not tell you which kind of ally you are, because that question belongs to the trap.)

Every one of them holds a little truth, which is why they last. Goodness matters, language matters, repair matters. The damage starts when one of them becomes the whole definition. The day allyship means being good, every exchange turns into a test you are taking, and the person in front of you stops being a person and becomes the examiner. You stop watching them and start watching yourself for proof that you passed. The help never lands, because you were looking at the scoreboard in your own head the whole time. You spend everything, they receive almost nothing, and you go home wondering why caring this much leaves you this empty. That emptiness is the receipt for a game that was never built to be won. It was built to keep you playing.

I know the machine from the inside; I ran it for three years while writing a book that told other people not to. It broke the day someone I had been “helping” told me, plainly, that my help had been about me the whole time. I wanted to argue. I could not. The scoreboard went dark, and behind it sat a question I had never asked: what if being good was never the game?

Here is the definition this book is built on.

Allyship is the practice of increasing another person's well-being while protecting the conditions that allow both of you to remain full players in the game.

Nothing in it asks whether you are good. The moment my help requires me to disappear, or turns you into a project or proof that I am good, we have left allyship. The definition guards one thing: the conditions where both of us can keep making real moves.

So you are not the defendant waiting on a verdict about your character. You are a player who has spent years inside a game someone else built. The myths are its rules, handed to you by people you trusted or absorbed so early you never saw them arrive, and you have been straining to win something that was rigged before you sat down. Here is the part the game would rather you not notice: you can look straight at it, decide it is not yours, and stand up. Once you are on your feet, you get to build a different game, with rules you would actually choose. That is what the rest of this book is for.

THE TOKEN SYSTEM — WHAT YOU'RE SPENDING

Every game runs on a currency, and the first rule you get to rewrite is what you pay with.

In the Arcade the currency is tokens, and there are two kinds. Most of us have only ever been handed the first. **Non-renewable tokens** come from scarcity: guilt, obligation, the need to be seen as good, the inherited debt you keep trying to retire. They are accelerant. They move you right now and bill you later, and the bill comes due in feeling worse about yourself, so every drop you burn has to be paid for by burning a little more of you. This is the fuel most allyship runs on. Show up, amplify, center, listen, do more: none of it wrong, all of it silent about the fact that you have been feeding the game your own body. (Yu-kai Chou spent a decade mapping exactly this — why some fuel keeps a player in the game and some quietly drives them out.)

Here is the myth this section takes apart. You have believed that the emptier you get, the more the care must have counted. Depletion looked like the proof that devotion leaves behind. It is a design flaw. You have been using yourself as the fuel, and a fire that eats its own hearth goes out.

The second kind is renewable tokens. They come from the satisfied states you reach by metabolizing a feeling all the way through, the ones you will meet by name in Chapter 2. They cost something too, and they hand back more than you spent. And they are not lying around to be collected. You make them.

Remember the anger I told you about, the anger I finally let myself feel? Here is the machine underneath that moment. For three years I ran this book on guilt, and guilt is that first kind of fuel: it got me to the desk and left me stranded there, emptier every month, until I was sitting in front of a chapter I could not write with no way to tell tired from done. The whole time there was a full tank I would not touch, the anger at the delay and at myself and at the gap between who I said I was and what I was doing, because a good ally stays in integrity and

does not get mad. The day I stopped swallowing it and actually burned it, it did not drain me. It moved me. The book got written on the fuel I had been treating as contraband.

That conversion has a name: Emotional Alchemy, the engine under the whole book. It takes the charge you are most afraid to spend (the fear, the anger, the sadness you were trained to keep down) and turns it into fuel that returns. What you can carry off this page is smaller and immediate: the charge that rises in a hard moment is ore, and you have been spending it as pure loss. The question stops being *can I afford to feel this*, and becomes *what is this, and can I burn it clean?*

You do not have to become the mint today. The move is smaller: stop believing you are only ever the battery. You are not a fixed supply being drawn down to nothing. You are someone who can make more of the very thing the game runs on. What that fuel earns you back, once you start spending it well, is the next thing on the floor.

THE TICKET SYSTEM — WHAT YOU'RE EARNING

Spend tokens in a real arcade and the machine, if you play well, spits out a run of tickets. You carry them to the counter in a sweaty fistful and trade them for a prize. That is the half of the economy the Token System left uncovered: what the playing pays back.

Allyship has a prize counter too, and most people have spent their whole lives feeding tickets into the wrong one. The counter marked applause pays out in being seen as good, in the right people nodding, in the post that does numbers. Those look like winnings. They are external, they vanish the moment the crowd turns, and you already know what they are worth: you perform the care, you feel like somebody for an hour, and you are empty by dinner. (I know that counter. I wrote whole chapters of this book standing at it and had to throw them out, because you can hear it in the prose, the hollow ring of a man collecting tickets instead of playing.)

The real prize is the one nobody can take back: a felt sense of satisfaction that only shows up when you actually played. You named the line and drew it. You held the field without giving up your walk-away price. You repaired the thing you would rather have avoided. You walk out tired and clear, and that clean tiredness is the prize, one of the satisfied states you will meet with the Shaman in Chapter 2.

Here is where the allyship Arcade breaks the rule of every arcade you have ever played. With the skee-ball and the stuffed bears, the prize is a dead end: you win the bear, the bear sits on a shelf, the game is over. Here, the prize converts back into tokens. The satisfaction you earn from playing well is renewable fuel, and it goes straight into the tank. This is why the better you play, the more you have to play with. A performance drains the tank and hands you a bear. A practice fills it, and a filled tank is the difference between burning out and getting to play for the rest of your life.

Return to the thing you brought with you. After you engage it, do you walk away with more fuel in the tank or less? That answer is your real score, whatever you looked like earning it.

WHY A GAME

The opening gave you one reason to run allyship as a game: the frame sets distance between you and the outcome, and it hands you clear rules and objectives in a place where most people are improvising blind. Detachment and clarity. That is the first reason.

Here is the second, and I will say it plainly, because it is the objection that makes serious people wave the whole idea away: a game is fun. If “fun” sounds too small for work this heavy, call it by its real name — engaging. A chore needs you to supply the motivation; you brace, you discipline, you drag yourself toward it. A game supplies the motivation itself. That is the entire difference between the two.

If making allyship a game feels like it cheapens something sacred, look at what the alternative actually costs. Most allyship is built as a chore — a duty, a debt, a weight good people carry — and it runs on the fuel we already named as the kind that empties you: obligation, guilt, the grim credit of having suffered for the cause. That model does not fail because people care too little. It fails because caring, run as suffering, burns down to nothing, and the person you showed up for is left standing there the day you finally collapse. Unless you are built to find meaning in your own depletion, a version of this work that offers you no engagement is a version you will quit.

Yu-kai Chou spent a decade mapping what actually keeps a human being playing — what pulls people back to some things for years and drives them out of others for good. Games are engineered around the first kind of pull. Allyship, almost always, is built out of the second. So a game is not a trick for making serious work go down easier. It is the only structure that generates the energy to keep doing serious work for a lifetime instead of one burnout cycle.

Which turns engagement from a nice-to-have into the whole engine — and building that engine is what the rest of this book is for. Allyship reaches you as three games running at once: the lucky breaks you cannot schedule, the skills you can actually build, and the love that keeps you coming back. Everything ahead is built to strengthen your hand in all three — to keep you present for the breaks when they come, to sharpen the moves that are yours to make, and to deepen the passion that keeps you at the machine long after discipline would have quit. That is the board we are about to map.

WHICH GAME ARE YOU PLAYING

Here they are, and each one pays out differently. Most frameworks teach one and treat the other two as mistakes. The move is to tell them apart, because you play each with a different hand.

Games of Chance — right place, right time.

You cannot control the right place or the right time. You can only control whether you are standing there when they arrive. A Game of Chance is the reorg that dissolves the case your coworker spent two weeks building the week before she files — timing you never touched, three floors up, deciding everything. And it is also the opposite: you are on a group thread you got copied on by habit, you catch that a hire is about to go sideways, and the one message you send, because you happened to be there to send it, is the reason the right person gets the job. Same game. You do not get to schedule either one.

That is why Chance pays the biggest of the three — jackpot money, the wins that reshape things. The price of that ceiling is that you cannot make it hit on command. So there is one way to play a Game of Chance well: stay in the game. Keep showing up in the places where the break could land, and refuse to read the losses as failure. When the reorg eats the case, you did not misplay it. You were in the game, which is the only move Chance rewards — and the jackpot you are still there for is real.

Games of Skill — the part you can build.

A Game of Skill is the one you actually control. Hearing what a person means underneath what they say is a skill. Naming your walk-away price and saying it before the pressure says it for you is a skill. Nobody is born fluent; you get them the way you get any skill, doing it badly and then less badly. The payout is honest and proportional — you get back about what your skill earns, no jackpot, no leverage, a steady wage for competence.

With one catch: a skill only pays where it is wanted. Bring the sharpest skeeball game in the world to an arcade whose owner is exhausted and going under, and you will not make a dime, because nobody there is playing. Skill is worth exactly what someone nearby actually needs it to be. So it is two moves, not one: build the skill, and take it to a floor where people are reaching for it.

Games of Passion — the ones you would play for free.

Then there is the game you would put your own quarters into. It has chance and skill inside it — every Game of Passion does — but the payout is not why you are at the machine. You are there because you love playing it, because it keeps handing you another corner of the world to explore, because you would come back tomorrow whether or not it ever paid. That is the tell of a Game of Passion: the playing is the prize.

And this is the game that keeps you in the Arcade at all. Chance needs you present for years before the jackpot lands. Skill needs you practicing long past boredom. Neither one survives on discipline alone — what keeps you at the machine through the dry spells is that some part of this you would do for love. Most frameworks call that love a liability, too invested, too irrational. In the Arcade it is the power supply. It is the reason you are still here, holding a book about allyship, when quitting was always the easier play.

So take the one you brought with you and sort it, once. Where is it Chance — moving on its own clock, asking only that you stay in the game? Where is it Skill — waiting for you to get better, and to carry that better to people who want it? And where is it Passion — the part you would keep playing after every reasonable person told you to stop? You do not need a clean answer. You just put your hands on the controls.

THE SIX FACES

You just sorted your situation into three kinds of game. Now meet the six who can teach you to play it.

Six Game Masters run the Infinite Arcade, and each one has spent a lifetime on a different kind of allyship game. The **Shaman** feels the thing before anyone can name it. The **Challenger** moves when everyone else freezes. The **Regent** keeps what works and hands it on. The **Architect** makes the right move the easy move. The **Diplomat** keeps people in the room who should have walked out an hour ago. The **Sage** sees which game is actually being played. Each of them plays all three games you just met — a jackpot they chase, a signature skill, a reason they keep coming back.

THE SIX GAME MASTERS



You already play one of these faces. The book is how you gain the range to reach for the one a moment actually needs.

You walked in already knowing how to play one of these games.

You have a home face — one you reach for without deciding to, one that feels like plain decency rather than a strategy. *That “without deciding” is your unconscious game master, still calling the moves.* You are good at this face. You have spent years sharpening it. You have also played it so hard, so long, that you have started to run its shadow.

The shadow lives in the face you overplay. Every face has one, and it is that face’s own strength pushed past the point where it still helps. The Diplomat keeps everyone in the room until nothing can be decided. The Challenger draws a clean line straight through the people he meant to protect. The Architect falls for the blueprint and never shows up in person. (If the first half of this chapter felt like it was reading your mail, that is one face’s shadow — the Diplomat’s — worn so long it stopped looking like a choice. I know that shadow from the inside: I kept this very book in the room for three years, everyone comfortable, nothing decided. If the Diplomat is your home face, you already know. If a different one is, you know it by its own shadow.)

You do care too much, and it costs you. You care about everyone — you would say so, and mean it — and you run all of that care through one face, on a field too narrow to hold it. It burns you down, because one face cannot carry that much. It misses, because one face is the wrong move as often as the right one.

Sometimes the friend, the coworker, the kid, the community you show up for needs a Challenger — one clean, costly line — and all you have is the Diplomat, so you keep the peace and they never get what they came for. Sometimes they need an Architect to change the rule that keeps hurting them, and you give them the Shaman’s feel for the room, and the rule does not move. The reason to widen your range is the person in front of you — the one who needed a move you did not have.

You already have the process that runs every one of these faces: the loop you meet in the next chapter. Each Game Master takes a chapter to teach you their game, and the loop is how you play it. By the end you reach for the face the moment needs instead of the one your hands find on their own.

You can feel which face is your home. Hold onto it. In the next section you put it on paper.

BUILD YOUR ALLYSHIP CHARACTER

This is your character sheet — a few lines, filled in for who you are right now.

Your home face. The one you already play — the one you just recognized as yours. Write it down.

Your shadow. Your home face has a bad night. Tired, scared, or spent, it stops being your strength and turns into the thing you overplay — the Diplomat who keeps the peace until nothing gets decided, the Challenger who scorches the room he came to protect. You catch

this one by feel: under strain it comes in heavier, tighter, more reactive than your real move. Write down the version of your face you fall into on empty. It is not your enemy; it is your tell.

Your myth. Back at the start you met the ten versions of *allyship means being good*. Write down the one that runs you hardest — the rule you have been playing by without ever agreeing to it. (The app’s Myths Read sorts your real top few, unflattering and exact, and turns each one into a first move.)

Your quest. Not “get better at allyship.” A cause. The specific fight, community, or person you are actually in this for. Name them. This is who your range is for.

That is the sheet for now. It fills in as you play: a superpower you will only spot in motion, an autopilot pattern you will catch yourself running, a line added in every chapter ahead.

Pen and paper hold this fine. The app holds it better — it keeps the sheet somewhere you will actually find it, dates every version, and shows you how your face, your shadow, and your myths move across a year of play, the change you cannot see from inside a single week. It is the same app that keeps your BARs, and your book comes with thirty days in it.

THE READER’S OATH

What follows is a bit of theater. Do it anyway. Every serious game keeps an oath — the scout’s, the athlete’s, the doctor’s — and you say the words out loud to drive them past your thinking mind, into the place where you actually make your moves.

So say it. Out loud if you can, because a thing said out loud is harder to take back.

I am playing this game. I am not the game.

I take the seat, and from here every move is chosen.

I will feel what rises and burn it clean, and never again spend myself as the fuel.

I will reach for the move they need, not only the one I know how to make.

I will guard the conditions that keep us both players.

I will fall short, and I will not call falling short a reason to leave.

I am not here to be good. I am here to keep playing.

This oath is not to me. You can’t fail me — you can only fail yourself.
The only way to lose is to stop playing.

CAPTURE WHAT LANDS — THE BAR DECK

I wrote this chapter to hit you. That is the craft, and by now some of it has. But I have sat on the other side of a book that hit me — more times than I can count — and I know what comes next, because it kept happening to me. The impact fades. By morning the charge is gone and

I am the same person I was before I opened it. Moved, and unchanged. If that is all this book does, I have failed, and so has every book you pick up after it.

The part of you that believes your life will change because you wrote it down in a journal is part of the problem. Writing is not the issue — putting the thought, the feeling, the experience on a page is halfway to something. What breaks is what happens to the page. It goes into a notebook you will almost never reopen, because reviewing a journal is genuinely hard and no one has made that part work. The impact goes in. It does not come back out.

BARs came out of a fix for this. Years ago I started carrying blank poker cards, and when something hit me — the kind of hit you know you will lose by morning — I wrote it on a card. The cards came with me. And here is the part I did not plan: even when I could not remember what a card said, I remembered where it lived. I was carrying a map of the moments that had changed me. The thing that hit me was in my pocket, in the palm of my hand, instead of on a shelf at home. That is what the notebook could not do.

A **BAR** is that card. Captured charge — one moment of your own play, caught while the heat is still on it, carried where you can reach it instead of filed where you cannot.

The name is the method. **B**reakthrough: what hit you. **A**ction: the one move it points to. **R**eflection: what changed when you moved. And the small **s** — sustain: what you keep for next time. The first two you write while the charge is live. The second two after you have spent it on a move.

The app is where the cards live now, so you are not carrying a paper deck in your coat. Every BAR becomes a card in a deck that is yours, built from what actually hit you instead of someone else's checklist. Read, capture, move, and by the last chapter you hold a deck no one else could have built. Stuck in a live moment a year from now, you draw from it and it hands you back something you earned once already. That is what the notebook on the shelf never did: it kept the thing that changed you where you could pick it up and play it again.

YOUR FIRST BAR

Before you go in, make your first BAR.

Something in this chapter hit you, or something from the last few days is still sitting with you. Find that one thing and write it down. One or two sentences, in whatever words are already in your head. You are not solving it or explaining it. You are catching it before it fades, the way I caught mine on those poker cards.

Then keep it on you. Put it in the app, where it becomes the first card in your deck and stays in reach for the rest of the book.

That is the whole move. You wrote down something that impacted you, and you kept it somewhere you will actually find it again. Reading gave you the hit. This is you keeping it.

Make the move.

Enter the Forest.

PLAYING ALONG

Your book comes with thirty days in the app, where the BAR you just wrote becomes the first card in your deck and your captures stay in reach as you read. Activate it, and find the hundred-and-twenty-card deck for when you want the moves in your hands, at [**URL / QR**].